Interuniversity Research & Innovation Student Expo

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Subject: GENERAL REPORT I-RISE & 7th CUK INNOVATION WEEK 2026

Inaugural (1st Annual) I-RISE Expo & The 7th CUK Innovation Week, 2026

8–9 October 2026 | The Co-operative University of Kenya

Theme: "Youth-Led Solutions for a Sustainable and Inclusive Nation: Where Ideas Rise to Impact"

1. Introduction

The Interuniversity Research & Innovation Student Expo (I-RISE) successfully hosted its inaugural (1st annual) edition together with the 7th CUK Innovation Week on 8–9 October 2026 at The Co-operative University of Kenya (CUK). The expo was held under the theme "Youth-Led Solutions for a Sustainable and Inclusive Nation: Where Ideas Rise to Impact", and brought together student innovators, university leadership, industry experts, investors and innovation partners.

I-RISE was designed as a platform for turning student research and ideas into practical, impact-driven solutions. Through project pitching, keynote and panel discussions, a partners and sponsors session, a startup and innovation showcase and an investor and ecosystem dialogue, the expo strengthened the link between universities, industry and the wider innovation ecosystem while nurturing a culture of innovation and entrepreneurship among young people.

The expo was organised by the I-RISE Organizing Committee together with the CUK Innovation Club, with the MC, Sinclair Ariga, guiding the programme across both days.

2. Participating Institutions

I-RISE 2026 was hosted by The Co-operative University of Kenya, which also served as the main sponsor of the expo. The programme featured the following partner universities:

- **The Co-operative University of Kenya (Host)**
- **Karatina University**
- **St. Paul's University**
- **The Catholic University of Eastern Africa (CUEA)**
- **Kaimosi Friends University**
- **Multimedia University of Kenya**
- **Kenyatta University**
- **Murang'a University of Technology**

These institutions mobilised students and innovators to showcase solutions to real societal challenges.

3. Participation and Projects

A total of 45 innovation projects were presented and scored across six thematic tracks, which were run in three parallel breakout rooms during the first pitching round:

The projects demonstrated creativity, research application and strong problem-solving skills from the participating teams.

4. Programme Overview

Day 1 – 8 October 2026

The first day focused on registration, the official opening, keynote and panel discussions, the first pitching round and engagement with partners and sponsors.

- **Arrival, Registration and Orientation (07:30–09:00):** handled by the I-RISE Organizing Committee.
- **Opening Ceremony (09:00–09:30):** featured the I-RISE Chairperson, Byron Korir; the Chairperson of the Innovation Committee, Dr. Shem Mbandu; the CUK Deputy Vice-Chancellor (ACDRI), Prof. Isaac Nyamongo; and the CUK Vice-Chancellor, Prof. Kamau Ngamau.
- **Keynote Innovation Address (09:30–10:00):** delivered by Derrick Gakuu, Chief Innovation Officer at SISCOM Technologies, a Nairobi-based fintech and digital-infrastructure entrepreneur whose company focuses on financing and co-owning cloud, GPU and data-centre infrastructure.
- **Tea Break and Group Photo (10:45–11:20).**
- **Project Pitching Round 1 (11:20–13:00):** teams pitched in three breakout rooms, each led by a track moderator – Room A (Bethwel), Room B (Laura) and Room C (Yvonne) – with each team given 5 minutes to pitch and 3 minutes for questions.
- **Pitching Continues (14:00–15:00):** after lunch, pitching resumed before the jury.

Day 2 – 9 October 2026

The second day focused on the final pitching round, jury deliberation, the startup and innovation showcase, investor engagement and the awards.

- **Registration (07:30–09:00).**
- **Final Pitching Round 2 (09:00–10:30):** the top two teams per theme made their final presentations before the jury panel.
- **Jury Deliberation (14:40–15:00)** followed by a tea break.
- **Partners and Sponsors Session (14:40–15:00):** featured ***Epic Academy, Fata School, Drift Plus, Drew Marketing, Kodes*** and ***Generation X Technologies***.
- **Awards and Closing Ceremony (15:00–15:30):** led by I-RISE and CUK leadership and committees.
- **Networking Lunch and Departure (15:30–16:00).**

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5. Evaluation and Results

Projects were evaluated by the jury panel within their thematic tracks. The scores awarded to each project were averaged, and teams were ranked by average score, both overall and within each theme. The final winners were then determined by the final jury panel following the Final Pitching Round 2 on Day 2, where the top two teams per theme presented their solutions.

5.1 Top Performing Teams

- ★ **Best Overall Winner: Argus**
- ★ **Best Overall Male Winner: Routeshield**
- ★ **Best Overall Female Winner: Neonatus Childcare**
- ★ **Runners-up Male Winner: The Digital Landlord**
- ★ **Runners-up Female Winner: Campus Link**

5.2 Ranking per Theme

AgriTech & Climate

Rank	Team	Average Score
1	**Pinacare**	85.33
2	Ecogeim	67.33
3	Farm Konnect	62.00
4	Urban Drain Digital Twin	61.67
5=	Farmlink 360	59.33
5=	Fishlink Port Victoria	59.33
7	Smart Farming	58.33
8	Tilapia Hub KE	55.50
9	AgriKenya	53.00
10	Pamoja Twaweza	52.00
11	Mavuno Green Grid	49.33
12	Farm Assistant	48.67
13	AgriKenya 2	47.50

Smart Mobility & Clean Energy

Rank	Team	Average Score
1	**Routeshield**	70.00

Cybersecurity, Ethical AI & LegalTech

Rank	Team	Average Score
1	Argus	74.00
2	**Minisco Sentri**	73.00
3	Smart Gate	67.00
4=	Net Hunters	66.33
4=	Solon	66.33
6	CyberShield	57.67

Education & Governance

Rank	Team	Average Score
1	**Sekani AI**	81.00
2	Public 254 – Mwananchi Voice	63.00
3	ElimuSaaS	42.00
4	Green Choice	38.00
5	Voting System	30.00

HealthTech & Inclusive Design

Rank	Team	Average Score
1	**Neonatus**	79.67
2	Signbridge	73.00
3=	Bee Multiscents	71.33
3=	GladFind	71.33
5	Truthscan	69.00
6	Okoa Patient	68.67

Rank	Team	Average Score
7	CareSync	67.50
8	Hecle	60.33
9	SHA-PAP	59.33
10	Dynamic Voice AI	58.00
11	CareFinder	56.00

FinTech & Inclusive Economies

Rank	Team	Average Score
1	**The Digital Landlord**	87.00
2	Campus Link	77.00
3	SmartReach AI	76.50
4	Househunt Kenya	76.00
5	BizTech	73.00
6	Saccosphere	59.00
7	CapitalNest	28.75
8	Equity Precheck	28.33
9	Experipesa	26.50

6. Key Achievements and Outcomes

The inaugural I-RISE Expo produced several significant outcomes:

- Over 45 student innovation projects were presented across six thematic tracks.
- Student innovators received practical exposure to project pitching, expert feedback and jury evaluation.
- Leaders from university management, industry and the innovation ecosystem engaged directly with the teams through the keynote, panel and partners sessions.
- The startup and innovation showcase and the investor and ecosystem dialogue opened pathways for promising projects to connect with partners and investors.
- Interuniversity collaboration was strengthened, laying a foundation for future annual editions of I-RISE.

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7. Partners and Sponsors

The success of I-RISE 2026 was made possible by the support of The Co-operative University of Kenya, as host and main sponsor, and of the following partners and sponsors who took part in the partners and sponsors session:

- **Epic Academy**
- **Fata School**
- **Drift Plus Adventures**
- **Drew Marketing Solutions**
- **Kodes**
- **Generation X Technologies**

These partners played an important role in supporting innovation dialogue and in the overall success of the expo.

8. Acknowledgement

The I-RISE Organizing Committee expresses sincere appreciation to all who contributed to the success of the inaugural I-RISE Expo and the 7th CUK Innovation Week.

Participants: We thank all student innovators and teams who dedicated their time and effort to develop and present their projects. Your courage, creativity and commitment to solving societal challenges made this event meaningful.

Universities: We appreciate the participating universities for mobilising students and supporting innovation activities.

Host Institution: Special gratitude goes to The Co-operative University of Kenya, led by the Vice-Chancellor, Prof. Kamau Ngamau, and the Deputy Vice-Chancellor (ACDRI), Prof. Isaac Nyamongo, for hosting the expo and providing an enabling environment for learning, collaboration and innovation.

Keynote Speaker : We thank Derrick Gakuu of SISCOM Technologies for inspiring the participants to turn ideas into impact.

Partners and Sponsors: We acknowledge the partners and sponsors who contributed expertise, mentorship and resources.

Jury and Track Moderators: We extend our appreciation to the jury panel and the track moderators who committed their time and professional expertise to evaluate projects and ensure a fair and constructive process.

Organizing Committee, MC and Volunteers: We thank the Organizing Committee, the MC, Sinclair Ariga, the Innovation Committee and all volunteers whose hard work ensured the smooth running of the programme.

9. Appreciation to All Teams

To all teams that participated in I-RISE 2026, we commend your dedication and hard work. To the top teams, congratulations on your outstanding innovations and presentations.

To the rest of the teams, well done for the effort and commitment you demonstrated. We encourage you to take the feedback from the jury constructively, refine your innovations and continue developing your solutions. Innovation begins with the willingness to step forward, and we look forward to seeing you again with even stronger projects.

10. Photo Highlights

Photos from both days of the expo (8 and 9 October 2026) can be accessed through the link below.

https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1eiHxepTl55Zm6D4CPOKnK83ijkz2xl1C?usp=sharing

11. Certificate Application and Feedback

All participants, whether or not they placed among the winners, are invited to apply for their certificates and to share feedback on the expo using the online form below. Applicants are asked to provide their official name exactly as it should appear on the certificate, together with their project or idea name. The feedback section is at the end of the form.

https://forms.gle/Q9M1MZcaWKJxVBePA

12. Conclusion and Forward Outlook

The inaugural I-RISE Expo and the 7th CUK Innovation Week demonstrated the power of collaboration between universities, industry and youth innovators. The event provided a strong platform for knowledge exchange, innovation development and partnership building.

Building on this success, I-RISE will continue to grow as an annual platform that expands interuniversity participation, strengthens industry partnerships and empowers young innovators to develop solutions for national and global challenges.

For any enquiries, please contact us at **irise.studentexpo@gmail.com** .

We look forward to building a strong and impactful partnership.

Yours faithfully,

I-RISE Organizing Committee
The Co-operative University of Kenya